NORTH CURRENT
Fact-check column, June 2026

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Slug: FACTCHECK ICE-OUT

Head: # Fact check: Was ice-out a month early on every Minnesota lake?

Dek: *It was an early spring almost everywhere. But a month early was rare, and up north some lakes opened right on schedule.*

Rating: **Partly true**

Art: Map by Lena Fischer, one dot per lake, from the DNR table. Breakup photo from the DNR archive, credit Minnesota DNR.

By Owen Brandt
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About 570 words, plus box and sources

The claim: A thread posted in late April says the ice went out a month early on every lake in Minnesota this spring. It has been shared more than 9,000 times.

How we checked: No one tracks ice-out on all of Minnesota's nearly 12,000 lakes, so the claim can only be tested on the lakes that are tracked. The Minnesota Department of Natural Resources collects ice-out dates every spring from volunteers, resort owners, lake associations and pilots. Some lakes' records go back more than a century, and for lakes with long records the DNR also lists a median date, the middle of all the years on file. We took every lake on this spring's list that has a median, 167 lakes in all, and counted the days between this year's ice-out and the median.

What we found: An early spring nearly everywhere, but not a month early everywhere. The typical lake went out 12 days ahead of its median. Most metro and southern lakes were two to three weeks early, and most lakes in central Minnesota one to two weeks early. In the north and the Arrowhead, most lakes opened within a few days of normal.

Close to a month: Seven of the 167 lakes went out four weeks or more ahead of their medians, and three of those made it to a full 30 days. All seven are small, shallow lakes, five in the metro and two in southern Minnesota. Shallow water warms fast, and those lakes opened in the first half of March. They fit the claim, and they are the exception.

Right on time: Six lakes, all in the north, went out on their median date or a day or two after it. On one lake north of Ely, where the same volunteer has logged ice-out every spring since 1987 and reports it to the DNR, the ice went out May 8, a couple of days later than his average. The thread went up before many northern lakes had opened at all.

Why the north lagged: Timing. The warmth that did the work came in March. That matters most in the south and the metro, where the ice usually goes out between late March and mid-April. Northern lakes carry thicker ice and usually open in late April or May, and by then, National Weather Service summaries show, temperatures up north were close to normal.

Why it matters: Earlier ice-out is part of a long-term pattern. On the lakes with the longest records, such as Lake Minnetonka, where ice-out dates go back to the 1850s, the ice tends to go out earlier now than it did a century ago. But the swings from one spring to the next are large. One early spring is weather. The pattern is in the long records.

One caution about the data: ice-out is an observer's call, usually some version of open water from one end of the lake to the other, and the definition varies a little from lake to lake. A day or two either way doesn't mean much. Three weeks does.

Rating: Partly true. The spring was early nearly everywhere, and the long-term shift toward earlier ice-out is real. But the claim's two key words, "every" and "month," are the parts that don't hold up. Most lakes went out one to three weeks early, a handful came close to a month, and up north some lakes opened right on time.

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BOX: How early was ice-out this spring?

Days between each lake's 2026 ice-out and its DNR median date, by region

Region	Lakes	Typical lake	Range
Twin Cities metro	38	18 days early	11 to 31 days early
Southern Minnesota	14	21 days early	14 to 30 days early
Central Minnesota	71	12 days early	6 to 19 days early
North and Arrowhead	44	3 days early	2 days late to 9 days early
Statewide	**167**	**12 days early**	**2 days late to 31 days early**

Lakes: those with both a 2026 date and a median. Typical lake: the middle value for the region. Source: Minnesota DNR ice-out records, pulled June 10, 2026.

SOURCES

1. Minnesota Department of Natural Resources: ice-out dates by lake for 2026, with median dates for lakes with long records (dnr.state.mn.us/ice_out), pulled June 10, 2026.
2. Minnesota State Climatology Office: spring 2026 climate summary.
3. National Weather Service, Twin Cities and Duluth offices: March to May 2026 climate summaries.
4. Lake Minnetonka ice-out record, 1855 to 2026, as listed by the DNR.
5. Ice-out log kept by a volunteer observer on a lake north of Ely, 1987 to 2026.